

# HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN RWANDA

## INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community effort in Rwanda is unusual, because the harms that most affect communities often come wrapped in genuinely celebrated green development and conservation, and because Rwanda is a tightly organised state with real environmental achievements but limited space for open dissent. Rwanda is admired around much of the world as a leading green model: it has protected its mountain gorillas back from the very brink of extinction, set aside nearly two-fifths of its national land for conservation, banned the plastic bag outright, kept its capital city famously clean and orderly, and is restoring the degraded wetlands of Kigali to hold back the floods. These are real and genuinely hard-won achievements, and this guide honours them plainly and without any reservation whatsoever. Yet the same strong, top-down drive that delivers these achievements can also fall heavily on ordinary communities: the wetland restorations and the green-city projects have evicted residents and expropriated their plots; the expropriation and resettlement carried out for development and for the clearing of high-risk zones displace families from their homes; and, in an older and harder pattern, conservation itself has pushed communities from the very lands they long depended on. The distinctive difficulty here is that the destructive project is very often a genuinely good project carried out in a way that harms the community — a wetland park that floods a neighbourhood with eviction notices, or a conservation scheme that quietly excludes the very people who once lived beside it. So the aim here is not to oppose green development but to insist it be done with communities, not to them.

A community in Rwanda works not to oppose green development but to insist it be done with them, not to them — and, in a tightly organised state, cautiously, through legal and international channels. The distinctive lever is the **state's own community-benefit promise**: Rwanda's stated commitment that green development benefits communities is a promise it can be held to, on its own terms. The **rights to fair compensation and genuine consultation** in expropriation and resettlement are real, if imperfectly honoured — a legal claim a displaced family can press. The **principle of benefit-sharing** — that communities share in the revenue and gains of conservation and green projects — can be pressed to be real. The **social and environmental safeguards of the international funders** who finance many of these projects carry accountability mechanisms a community can invoke. And the **environmental and resettlement assessment** is a formal gate. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Rwanda's green projects are genuinely valuable and the state has real reasons for them, so the aim is never to oppose them but to make them fair. The space for open opposition is constrained, with real red lines around politics, security, and criticism of the government, so the work must be cautious, legal, technical, and international, framed around the community's rights and the state's own promise, never around challenging authority, and protecting those involved. The green model is entrenched and celebrated. And no ordinary grassroots victory is to be promised. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a displaced community fairly compensated, genuinely consulted, and included; the benefit-sharing made real; the funders' safeguards honoured; the state held to its own promise — so that green development is done with communities, not to them, cautiously and through the legal and international channels. Above all, keep it to the community's rights, and protect the people.

## The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You do not oppose Rwanda's green development, which is genuinely valuable — you insist it be done with communities, not to them. Hold the state to its own promise that green development benefits communities; press the rights to fair compensation and genuine consultation in expropriation and resettlement; make the benefit-sharing real; and invoke the international funders' safeguards — all cautiously, through legal and international channels, framed around the community's rights, never around challenging authority, and protecting those involved.

## Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Rwanda is a distinctive, celebrated, tightly organised setting, and honesty about it is the first discipline. The green projects are genuinely valuable and the state has real reasons for them, so this is never a fight to oppose green development — only to make it fair. The space for open opposition is constrained, with real red lines, so the work is cautious, legal, and international, never confrontational. So the realistic aim is a displaced community fairly compensated, genuinely consulted, and included, the benefit-sharing made real, and the state held to its own promise — done with communities, not to them, and protecting everyone.

## HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

### Who Actually Decides

Power in Rwanda is strong and top-down, but the decisions a cautious effort can reach run through rights, promises, and funders: the **government and its lands, environment, and resettlement bodies** that carry out the expropriation and green projects; the **compensation and consultation law** that governs them; the **benefit-sharing schemes** around conservation; and the **international funders and their safeguards** that finance much of it. Keep clear of the red lines, and map who decides a project and which right or safeguard reaches it before spending a week on it.

### How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A green or development project — a wetland park, a resettlement, a conservation scheme — moves through the state's top-down drive, with an environmental and resettlement assessment and a compensation and consultation process. That assessment and process is your entry point: the moment to press for genuine consultation, fair compensation, and inclusion, and to invoke the state's own community-benefit promise. For internationally funded projects, the funders' safeguards are a further entry point. Enter through the community's rights, cautiously, and framed around fairness, not opposition.

### Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the project: which green or development scheme displaces or excludes the community, and whether its consultation and compensation were genuine. Follow the promise: the state's own commitment that green development benefits communities. Follow the benefit-sharing: whether the community shares in the conservation or green revenue. Follow the finance: which international funders back it, and what safeguards they impose. The leverage lies in the state's own promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the funders' safeguards.

### Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here are the lands, environment, and resettlement bodies, the compensation and consultation law, the benefit-sharing schemes, and — crucially — the international funders and their safeguard and accountability mechanisms. A case engages these cautiously, holding the state to its own promise and the

funders to their safeguards, framed around the community's rights.

## QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Rwandan community easily halts a celebrated green project, and honesty requires saying so — nor should the aim be to oppose genuinely valuable development. What the tools can deliver is a community fairly compensated, genuinely consulted, and included, and the benefit-sharing made real. The single most decisive move is **holding the state to its own community-benefit promise and pressing the compensation and consent rights, backed by the funders' safeguards**, because a state that celebrates green development as good for communities is exposed when it harms them, and because the funders' safeguards carry real accountability. The state's own promise is the distinctive lever; the compensation and consent rights the legal claim; the benefit-sharing the fair share; the funders' safeguards the accountability. The realistic prize is fairness and inclusion, not opposition.

## STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the eviction, expropriation, resettlement, or exclusion, wrapped in a green or development project. **Was it done fairly?** — the consultation, compensation, and inclusion, or their absence. **Which right applies?** — the fair-compensation and genuine-consultation rights. **What promise does it strain?** — the state's own community-benefit commitment. **Is it funded internationally?** — whose safeguards apply. Pick the fight where the state's own promise, the compensation rights, or the funders' safeguards give the clearest, most cautious handle — and always for fairness, not against the project.

## STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers, cautiously. **Layer one: the harm** — the eviction, expropriation, or exclusion, and the community's loss, documented carefully. **Layer two: the right and the promise** — the compensation and consultation the law requires, the state's own community-benefit promise, the benefit-sharing owed, the funders' safeguards the project breaches or strains. **Layer three: the channel and the caution** — which legal, benefit-sharing, or funder mechanism to engage, and the discipline of framing it around the community's rights, keeping clear of the red lines, and protecting those involved. A case built on the community's rights and the state's own promise, framed for fairness not opposition, is one the system can receive.

## WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the eviction or exclusion, the community's loss, the inadequate consultation or compensation. Gather the **rights record**: the compensation and consultation law, the benefit-sharing principle. Gather the **promise record**: the state's own community-benefit commitments. Gather the **finance record**: the international funders and their social and environmental safeguards. Gather the **caution discipline**: confirm the work is framed around rights and fairness, clear of the red lines, and protective of those involved.

## STEP 3: BUILDING THE RIGHTS-BASED COALITION

The coalition here is rights-based, cautious, and framed for fairness. Build it from the **affected community**, whose compensation, consultation, and inclusion are the claim, protected from exposure; the **legal advocates** who can press the compensation and consent rights; the **benefit-sharing and community-development bodies**; and the **international funders and their safeguard mechanisms**. Frame everything around the community's rights and the state's own promise — that green development benefits communities — never around opposing the project or challenging authority; keep clear of the red lines; and protect those involved.

## STEP 4: THE STATE'S PROMISE, THE RIGHTS & THE SAFEGUARDS — MAKING GREEN DEVELOPMENT FAIR

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by a tightly organised state, so the prize is fairness and inclusion, not opposition or a grassroots stop.

### The State's Own Promise and the Rights

The distinctive lever is the **state's own community-benefit promise** — that green development benefits communities — a commitment it can be held to. And the **rights to fair compensation and genuine consultation** in expropriation and resettlement are real, if imperfectly honoured. Hold the state to its promise and press the rights.

### The Benefit-Sharing

The **principle of benefit-sharing** — that communities share in the revenue and gains of conservation and green projects — can be pressed to be real, so that those who bear a project's costs also share its benefits. Press the benefit-sharing to be genuine.

### The Funders' Safeguards

The **social and environmental safeguards of the international funders** who finance many of these projects carry accountability mechanisms a community can invoke, and the **environmental and resettlement assessment** is a formal gate. Pursued together — the state's promise and the rights, the benefit-sharing, and the funders' safeguards — these levers make green development fair, done with communities not to them, while protecting those involved.

## TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always for fairness. **For the state and its bodies**: here is a green project that harms the community, against your own promise that it should benefit them. **For the compensation and consultation law**: here is a family owed fair compensation and genuine consultation. **For the benefit-sharing schemes**: here is a community owed its share. **For the international funders**: here is a project breaching your social and environmental safeguards. **For the assessment**: here is a resettlement done without proper process. **The golden rule**: hold the state to its own promise, press the community's rights and benefit-sharing, invoke the funders' safeguards, frame it for fairness not opposition, keep clear of the red lines, and protect those involved.

## STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a tightly organised state, and largely through legal and international channels. Frame any attention around **the community's rights and the state's own promise**: a green project that should benefit communities but instead harms them, and the fair compensation, consultation, and inclusion owed — never around opposing green development or challenging authority. Carry it through the legal, benefit-sharing, and international funder channels rather than open confrontation. A few cautions govern everything: keep it to the community's rights and fairness; honour the green project's value; keep clear of the red lines; protect those involved; and let the state's own promise and the funders' safeguards carry the weight.

## EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message cautious, rights-based, framed for fairness, and protective of those involved.

**8A — To the state or resettlement body**: set out how the green project harms the community against the state's own promise that it should benefit them.

**8B — On the compensation and consent rights**: press the fair compensation and genuine consultation the law requires.

**8C — On the benefit-sharing**: claim the community's genuine share in the conservation or green revenue.

**8D — To an international funder**: flag the project's breach of your social and environmental safeguards.

**8E — On the assessment**: request the proper environmental and resettlement process.

**8F — To a legal advocate**: coordinate the rights-based claim, cautiously.

**8G — To the community**: organise the claim for fair treatment, framed around rights, protecting those involved.

**8H — To an international body**: describe the harm and request engagement, framed for fairness.

## IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

**The first 48 hours**: document the eviction, exclusion, or inadequate compensation; identify the state's own promise and the rights it strains; check whether the project is internationally funded. **The fastest-moving levers**: the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, and the funders' safeguards. **Emergency action**: for an internationally funded project, the funders' safeguard mechanisms; for any expropriation, the compensation and consultation rights. Throughout, frame it for fairness, keep clear of the red lines, and protect those involved.

## WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a strong, top-down state and a celebrated green model that is genuinely valuable and entrenched. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily dismiss: the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing principle, and the international funders' safeguards. And accept the honest limits — the green projects are valuable, the space constrained, the model celebrated — while still insisting green development be done with communities not to them, framed for fairness, and protecting those involved.

## WHEN IT'S ACTUAL INJUSTICE — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the injustice is usually not corruption but a good project done in a way that harms the community — an eviction without fair compensation, a conservation scheme that excludes those who lived beside it. Respond through the cautious, rights-based channels: the state's own promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the funders' safeguards. Never through open confrontation or anything touching the red lines. **On safety and care:** this note matters throughout. Rwanda is a tightly organised state with real red lines around politics, security, and criticism of the government; while claiming compensation and inclusion is more tolerated than overt political dissent, the work must still be careful. Favour the legal, technical, and international channels over open confrontation; frame the work around the community's rights and the state's own promise, never around challenging authority; keep clear of the red lines; and protect those involved. Care is the first rule.

## INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, cautiously and framed for fairness. The documented harm feeds the rights claim, the benefit-sharing case, and the funders' safeguard appeal at once; the community and legal advocates organise around fairness; any attention frames it around the state's own promise. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the rights and promise it strains; **months two to six**, press the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, the state's promise, and the funders' safeguards; **beyond**, secure the fairness and inclusion, and hold it. The core discipline: rights-based, fairness-framed, cautious, and protective of those involved.

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

Rwanda is a distinctive, celebrated, tightly organised ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a community can readily halt a celebrated green project, or that the space for open opposition is other than constrained, or that the green achievements are anything but genuinely valuable — none of that is true, and this guide honours those achievements without reservation. What it claims is real: that the destructive project here is often a good project done in a way that harms the community, and that the aim is not to oppose green development but to insist it be done with communities, not to them. The state's own promise that green development benefits communities is a commitment it can be held to; the rights to fair compensation and genuine consultation are real; the benefit-sharing can be pressed to be genuine; and the international funders' safeguards carry accountability. The levers are cautious, rights-based, and constrained, and the prize is a community fairly compensated, genuinely consulted, and included, the benefit-sharing made real, and the state held to its own promise — not opposition to valuable development. For a celebrated green state that promises community benefit, that careful, rights-based work — done for fairness, keeping clear of the red lines, and protecting those involved — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one, because green development should be done with communities, not to them.